

WEEK 2 · FINOPS

Five places your cloud cost hides.

You cannot cut what you cannot see. A practical guide to the usual suspects behind a climbing AWS bill.

INSIDE

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Five places AWS spend hides, what each looks like, where to look in your own account and what to do first.

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INTRODUCTION

A climbing bill is rarely one big mistake.

It is usually many small ones, running quietly where nobody is looking. The good news: they tend to hide in the same five places, and each one can be found with tools already in your AWS account.



Visibility comes first

Before anything can be cut, someone has to see it, name it and know who owns it.



Every cost needs an owner

Spend without an owner is spend nobody will question. Ownership turns a number into a decision.



Finding it once is not enough

Waste returns. The habit of looking every month is what keeps the bill honest.

01

PART 01

The five usual suspects.

Each one looks harmless on its own. Together they explain most surprise bills.

01 Idle and oversized compute

02 Storage nobody deletes

03 Data on the move

04 Forgotten environments

05 Commitments that do not fit

01



Idle and oversized compute

Instances sized for a peak that never comes, or left running overnight and at weekends.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Low utilisation week after week. Development servers running around the clock. Instance types chosen years ago and never revisited.

WHY IT HAPPENS

Teams size for safety, and nobody is asked to size down once the system settles.

WHERE TO LOOK

AWS Compute Optimizer recommendations, and CPU and memory utilisation in CloudWatch.

WHAT TO DO FIRST

Schedule non-production to stop out of hours, then rightsize the clearest cases.



OWNER

Engineering lead for each workload

Bring this to the monthly review, with a date for each action.

02



Storage nobody deletes

Volumes, snapshots and buckets that outlive the work they were created for.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Unattached EBS volumes. Snapshots from servers long gone. Buckets with everything in the most expensive tier.

WHY IT HAPPENS

Deleting feels risky, keeping feels free, and nobody owns the clean-up.

WHERE TO LOOK

EBS volumes in the available state, the snapshot list sorted by age, and S3 Storage Lens.

WHAT TO DO FIRST

Agree a retention rule, delete what is clearly orphaned and add lifecycle policies to buckets.



OWNER

Platform or infrastructure team

Bring this to the monthly review, with a date for each action.

03



Data on the move

Traffic between zones, regions and the internet that nobody designed to be costly.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Data transfer lines growing faster than the services that cause them. NAT gateways processing more than expected.

WHY IT HAPPENS

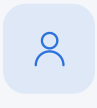
Architecture choices made for resilience or convenience, without a view of what moving data costs.

WHERE TO LOOK

Cost Explorer grouped by usage type, filtered to data transfer and NAT gateway charges.

WHAT TO DO FIRST

Find the top flows, then review VPC endpoints, placement and caching for the biggest ones.



OWNER

Solution architect

Bring this to the monthly review, with a date for each action.

04



Forgotten environments

Test, demo and proof-of-concept stacks that outlived the project they were built for.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Resources with no tags, unfamiliar names or a creator who has since left the business.

WHY IT HAPPENS

Spinning up is easy and celebrated. Shutting down is nobody's job.

WHERE TO LOOK

Untagged resources in Tag Editor, and stacks with no named owner or recent activity.

WHAT TO DO FIRST

Tag or turn off. Anything with no owner after a fair notice period gets switched off.



OWNER

Each project or product owner

Bring this to the monthly review, with a date for each action.

05



Commitments that do not fit

Paying on-demand rates for steady workloads, or committing to usage that has since moved.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Steady, predictable workloads with no commitment at all, or Savings Plans that are no longer fully used.

WHY IT HAPPENS

Commitments are bought once, then the estate changes underneath them.

WHERE TO LOOK

Savings Plans and Reserved Instance coverage and utilisation reports in the Billing console.

WHAT TO DO FIRST

Review coverage and utilisation before buying or renewing anything new.



OWNER

Finance with engineering

Bring this to the monthly review, with a date for each action.

RUN IT YOURSELF

A one-hour cost hunt

Block an hour with one engineer and one person from finance. Work through the five suspects in this order and leave with named owners.

01 **Open Cost Explorer and group by service**

Note the top services and anything that grew since last month.

02 **Check compute utilisation**

List instances with consistently low use, and anything non-production running all week.

03 **List orphaned storage**

Unattached volumes, old snapshots and buckets without lifecycle rules.

04 **Look at data transfer lines**

Find the biggest flows and ask whether they were designed or accidental.

05 **Review untagged resources and commitments**

Find what has no owner, then check commitment coverage and utilisation.

06 **Assign an owner to every finding**

One name per item, with a date to come back to it.

REMEMBER

The goal of the first hour is not savings. It is a list of findings with an owner against each one.

CHECKLIST

The five suspects, ticked off

Use this each month. Anything you cannot tick goes on the list with an owner.

- [ ] **Compute is sized to real use**
  Non-production stops out of hours.

- [ ] **No unattached volumes or stale snapshots**
  Retention rule agreed and applied.

- [ ] **Data transfer is understood**
  Top flows reviewed and explained.

- [ ] **Every resource has an owner**
  Untagged resources tagged or switched off.

- [ ] **Commitments match usage**
  Coverage and utilisation checked before any purchase.

- [ ] **Findings have owners and dates**
  Reviewed again next month.

TRANSPUTEC

Find yours before the next invoice.

Most estates have at least one of these. We can run the hunt with you and leave you with a clear, owned list.

Ask for a cost review

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